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Examining the Use of Team Selling by Manufacturers' Representatives

A Situational Approach

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Because of their boundary-spanning nature, manufacturers' representatives frequently are involved in team selling. The results from a survey of 362 manufacturers' representatives indicates that team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when the customer faces a first-time buy of a complex product, when the information needs of the customer are great, when the account requires special treatment, and when a number of people are involved in the decision to buy. In addition, team selling is more likely when the potential sale is large for the representative firm and when the product is new to the representative's product line.

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There are three distinct types of team selling.

INTRODUCTION

Manufacturers' representatives are frequently used in U.S. industries. It is estimated that half of all U.S. companies today use manufacturers' representatives exclusively, or at least for one division [23]. In business-to-business transactions, independent manufacturers' representatives or agents account for almost 50 % of sales [28, 2].

Manufacturers' representatives are key intermediaries, bridging the gap between manufacturers, distributors, and customers. To ensure effective performance, relationships must be built between manufacturers' representatives, other channel members, and customers.

One way to develop stronger relationships and increase the flow of two-way information in the channel is through the use of team sales [15,3]. Blessington describes selling teams as a combination of sales and nonsales personnel, under the direction of a leader who sets strategy and coordinates information flows. The members in the selling team can be anyone within or outside the firm with knowledge of products, customers, or the industry that can benefit the seller [5]. This definition of selling teams is particularly suited to team selling with manufacturers' representatives, where the members of the selling team can be from the manufacturer, distributor, or within the manufacturers' representatives own firm.

Despite the importance of the use of team selling with manufacturers' representatives, little or no research examines why and when team selling is used by these intermediaries. Broadly speaking, there has been some effort to propose relationships between team selling activities and situational variables but only for in-house sales forces [10, 15, 20, 25, 27]. Such propositions, however, have not been empirically tested for either manufacturers' representatives or in-house sales forces.

The purpose of this paper is to conduct an exploratory study into the situations in which team selling is used by manufacturers' representatives and to suggest areas for future research on team selling.

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LITERATURE REVIEW AND HYPOTHESES

Based upon a review of trade and academic literature and discussions with many manufacturers' representatives, there are three distinct types of team selling in which manufacturers' representatives may engage. In the first type, personnel from the principal's firm accompany their representatives on joint calls to customers [9]. The principal's liaisons may assist in training both the manufacturers' representative and the customer in the features and proper use of the products, may provide technical selling support to assist in making the sale, may observe and get a feel for the market, or may monitor the representative's performance [14].

In the second type, members of the representative's firm make joint calls on customers with distributor's salespeople [17]. In these cases, the manufacturers' representative might provide technical assistance or sales support or otherwise assist in making sales. In addition, the manufacturers' representative might train the distributor's salespeople in the products and markets to be served or might gather information used in training the distributor's salespeople [17].

The third type of team selling involves creating teams composed of individuals from within the manufacturers' representative's firm. This type of team selling is the most similar to that performed by an in-house sales force and is used for training, support, or supervision of individual salespeople [30, 6, 7, 8]. These three different types of team sales with manufacturers' representatives are distinct, because they are composed of individuals from different autonomous organizations. Individuals from these organizations may bring such different abilities to the selling team as greater product knowledge (from the principal's firm) or greater customer knowledge (from the distributor's firm). In addition, the selling teams that are composed of individuals from the representatives firm and an outside organization (principals or distributors) may be more difficult and costly to form than selling teams composed of members from within the representative's firm because of lack of close physical proximity and/or unfamiliarity between the team members. This higher cost, as well as the differing ability of the individuals in the three different types of team selling, may create variance in how each is used. To be able to control for and understand these potential variances, each hypothesis developed below is explored for each of these three forms of team selling with manufacturers' representatives.

The literature suggests that team selling is an effective method when the informational needs of the buyer are great [29]. When the buyer needs a great deal of information in a purchase situation, a salesperson may not have the depth or breadth of knowledge required by the buyer [24]. Dunn and Thomas [10] focus on the possible existence of a product-expertise gap between the seller and the buyer . The product-expertise gap occurs when the seller knows more about the product than the customer. This situation necessitates the transfer of substantive information, often in large quantities between the buyer and the seller. In the case of a product-expertise gap, team selling allows for the direct incorporation of product or technical experts in the selling process to provide the information necessary to reduce or close the gap. Moon [20] argues that if there is a buyer-expertise gap, where the buyer does not know much about the product or service and requires information to close this gap, technical experts or other salespeople can be brought in to the selling team to provide the needed information. This leads to the first hypothesis:

H1: Team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when the information needs of the customer are greater.

A customer buying a product or service for the first time may need more information about the various offerings . Several researchers hypothesize that team selling is more appropriate when the buyer is faced with a novel purchase situation or a new task buying situation [15, 31]. In an exploratory study of selling team members in a business-to-business setting, Moon and Armstrong [20] found that the use of team selling increased, and the complexity of the selling team increased when the purchase situations were novel to the buyer and when the importance of the purchase increased for the buyer. Similarly, Raman [25] proposes that team selling is more effective when it is a new buy situation. This makes it very important for the buyer to understand the offering fully to ensure that the proper product is purchased. Because of the greater informational needs and financial risks, sales teams may be needed to meet the informational needs of the customer. Thus, the second hypothesis states:

H2: Team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when the customer has not purchased the product previously.

When a product or service is complex, a buyer-expertise gap may exist, because the purchasing organization does not know much about the product [20]. To reduce this gap, the buyer needs added information. Complex products or services usually represent a larger financial risk and time commitment on the part of the buyer [11]. The third hypothesis is:

H3: Team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when the product they sell is complex.

Special needs of the customer may require special treatment by the seller [20]. Special treatment is defined as providing product or transaction benefits not generally offered to the typical customer. This is compared to standard treatment, which is the treatment that most normal accounts receive. To understand the special needs of the customer better and the special organizational resources that can be used to meet those needs, manufacturers' representatives can include different types of specialists on the selling team [29, 31]. Special treatment might include uniquely designed products or services to meet the particular needs of the customer, specific types of delivery systems (e.g., just-in-time inventory control), or financing arrangements not offered to the representative's other customers. Other examples might include high-priority service support and/or a dedicated sales representative who services only that customer. These special treatments might require including representatives from the manufacturing, engineering, distribution, finance, or other departments on the selling team. Thus, the fourth hypothesis is:

Team selling is expensive.

H4: Team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when the account requires special treatment.

In most situations, more than one person is involved in the buying center [16]. These individuals may each have their own informational needs. The challenge to the representative's organization of meeting these different information needs is magnified when the individuals in the buying center come from diverse parts of the purchasing organization and, thus, have different interests and backgrounds [25]. Given these diverse information needs, it may be impossible for one salesperson to understand each member's information needs and to have the knowledge to respond to these needs [13]. In these situations, it may become necessary to include more individuals on the sales team who are similar to those making the decision and are able to understand and meet the unique information needs and communication style of each buying center member [20]. Thus, the fifth hypothesis states:

H5: Team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when the number of people who need to be influenced in one sales session is greater.

According to Raman [25], the effectiveness of a team approach depends upon the characteristics of the transaction. There are several characteristics of team selling that should limit its use to specific transactions. First, team selling is expensive. There is an added expense when individuals are taken from multiple functional departments or organizations to call on customers. Second, there are potential problems with the cohesiveness of the team given the diverse backgrounds and training of individual team members. To be effective, selling as a team must be rehearsed and practiced; furthermore, the composition, compensation, and coordination of the team should not be casual considerations. A generalization of these factors and others which have been proposed in the team selling literature is that team selling should only be used in situations where the added benefit or profit outweighs the added costs [25, 21]. These cost characteristics should limit the use of team selling to those transactions where sales are relatively large. When the sale is large to the representative's firm, the benefits of using team sales might outweigh the costs [12]. In these situations, people from the principal's organization may accompany the representative. Likewise, the representative might accompany a distributor's salesperson, or upper management or other personnel from the representative's firm might become involved in the sales team to ensure that all of the purchase objections are answered satisfactorily and that the importance of the sale is communicated to the buyer [20]. The time spent by the representative's salespeople, management, principals, and distributors are valuable commodities, and the allocation of these resources to a buyer communicates the commitment the team feels toward that customer. Also, if the sale is large, the representative will not want to lose it to a competitor who might be using team selling [7]. This relationship is also supported in the channels literature. Narus and Anderson indicate that joint calls should be conducted on high potential accounts where sales may be large [22]. Thus, the sixth hypothesis is:

H6: Team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when the size of the sale to the representative's organization is greater.

When representatives are selling a new product or service, their salesforce will have less knowledge of or experience with that product. Because of their lack of experience, representatives' salespeople may not have the knowledge to answer all of the customer's questions. Thus, a sales manager, someone from the principal's firm, or another person with technical expertise may join the representative's salesperson to ensure that all the potential questions can be answered [13]. In addition, members of the manufacturers' representative firm may accompany the representative when selling products new to the line to provide additional information about the product or to observe the customers' reaction to the new product. On the other hand, if members of the salesforce do have experience in selling the product, they may have the ability to answer all of the customer's questions without having to involve other individuals in the sale. Thus, the seventh hypothesis is:

A survey of independent manufacturers' representatives was undertaken

H7: Team selling is more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when introducing a product that is new to the representative's product line.

METHOD

A survey of independent manufacturers' representatives was undertaken to test the hypotheses. To gain insight into the three types of team selling performed by manufacturers' representatives (principal/ representative sales teams, distributor/ representative sales teams, and within-firm representative sales teams), three different questionnaires were designed to determine the extent to which sales teams were used in different buying and selling situations. Because each of the representatives' firms potentially used all three types of team selling, the initial part of each questionnaire instructed the respondents on which particular type of team selling they were to refer to when completing the questionnaire (e.g., with one of your principals, with a distributor, or with someone from within your own firm). Respondents were also instructed to skip the questions dealing with the hypotheses and go on to some general questions about team selling if they did not engage in the type of team selling referred to in the questionnaire.

The membership list of the Manufacturers' Representative Educational Research Foundation (MRERF) was used to select the sample for the study. MRERF membership includes representatives from 26 different associations, including representatives who sell electronics, food, general merchandise, automotive parts, office products, plumbing supplies, power transmission, and safety equipment. MRERF members total approximately 6000 representative firms. Cost, questionnaire length, and difficulty of contact, collectively, precluded a telephone survey from consideration. Based upon the nature of the questions and the geographic dispersion of the population, a mail survey was deemed appropriate. Three questionnaires were developed. One questionnaire focused on manufacturers' representatives sales calls with personnel from principals' firms (principal sales teams), another on manufacturers' representative sales calls with salespeople from distributors' firms (distributor sales teams), and the third on sales calls with individuals within the manufacturers' representative's own firm (within-firm sales teams). The three questionnaires were pretested on a group of approximately 30 manufacturers' representatives to ensure clarity and to avoid ambiguous wording. Questionnaires were distributed and completed and then were discussed in a focus group atmosphere. The pretest resulted in modifying the wording in several of the questions.

Fifteen hundred manufacturers' representatives were randomly selected from the membership list and were mailed questionnaires. The sample was randomly partitioned into three equal groups of 500 members. Each member received one of the three questionnaires. A total of 196 usable questionnaires (70 principal, 69 distributor, and 57 within-firm) were returned for a response rate of 13%. Although the response rate was low, it was not unexpected given the complexity of the questionnaire, which also sought other information on manufacturers' representatives not used in this paper.

To expand the sample, additional, self-administered questionnaires were distributed at a manufacturers' representatives educational conference attended by MRERF members. The three types of questionnaires were randomly assigned to participants who were directed to fill out the questionnaires and return them to the authors. Again, if participants did not engage in the type of team selling indicated on the questionnaire, they were told to skip over the questions dealing with the hypotheses. Furthermore, participants were instructed not to fill out the questionnaire if they had previously responded to the mail survey. One hundred ninety questionnaires were distributed and 165 returned, for a response rate of 85.3%. Forty-four of the returned questionnaires were "principal," 64 were "distributor," and 57 were "within-firm" questionnaires. These questionnaires were coded separately from those collected through the mail survey to compare the two samples. Analysis of the variables

76.4% engaged in some form of team selling.

utilized in the study indicated that there were no statistically significant differences (alpha $< .05$) between the two samples regarding demographic characteristics of each subgroup and regarding the mean responses for each of the measurement variables. Therefore, the two samples were pooled for the remainder of the analysis. The similarity of the two samples and their responses also alleviated concern for nonresponse bias in the mail survey.

RESULTS

Respondent Characteristics

The average age of the respondents was 45 years. Respondents averaged 15.6 years of formal education and 20.7 years of selling experience. The average number of salespeople in the respondents' firms was 7.47 and the average number of principals represented was 14.

Of the 361 responses received, 282 (76.4%) indicated that they engaged in some form of team selling. This large percentage indicates how widespread and important team selling is. Of the three types of team selling, the respondents reported that on average they engage in team selling with distributors the most frequently (mean 18.0% of their calls), followed by team selling with principals (mean 14.3% of their calls), and that they engaged in team selling within their own firms the least frequently (mean 12.6% of their calls).

Hypotheses Tests

Measures used to test the hypotheses each consisted of two 7-point itemized rating scales designed to assess the extent to which team selling was used in a particular buying or selling situation. For example, to measure the extent to which team selling is used when the buyer's informational needs are great, respondents indicated the likelihood of using sales teams when "the anticipated information needs of the customer are small" and "the anticipated information needs of the customer are great" (1 = extremely unlikely, 7 = extremely likely). T-tests were conducted on the mean differences between the respondents' ratings for each of the paired questions. A hypothesis was supported when the mean difference was significantly different from 0. A complete list of questions used to test the hypotheses is provided in Appendix A.

Difference tests were examined jointly. In all, 24 difference tests were performed (8 hypotheses x 3 types of selling teams). Because of the large number of comparisons, the Bonferroni inequality was used to adjust the alpha level to account for chance relationships. To achieve an over-all error rate no greater than 0.05 for the entire set, a single comparison error rate of $0.05/24 = 0.002$ was established [19]. That is, no single comparison was concluded to be statistically significant unless the t-value was less than 0.002. All results discussed in this section were significant based on this criterion.

The results are summarized in Table 1. Results confirmed that selling teams tend to be used in a number of different buying situations and that this occurred for all three types of selling teams. Team selling is more likely to be used when the anticipated information needs of the customer are great rather than small. This finding was significant for within-firm selling teams ($t = 16.06$, $p < .000$), for principal selling teams ($t = 18.34$, $p < .000$) and for distributor selling teams ($t = 9.95$, $p < .000$). Thus, *H1* is supported.

All three kinds of selling teams are more likely to be used when the buyer faces a first-time buy (within-firm selling teams, $t = 6.10$, $p < .000$; principal selling teams, $t = 5.35$, $p < .000$, distributor selling teams, $t = 6.41$, $p < .000$). When the product is complex, selling teams are more likely to be used than when the product is simple (within-firm selling teams, $t = 20.70$, $p < .000$; principal selling teams, $t = 17.67$, $p < .000$, distributor selling teams, $t = 7.57$, $p < .000$). Similarly, when the account requires special treatment, within-firm selling teams ($t = 14.75$, $p < .000$), principal selling teams ($t = 14.93$, $p < .000$), and distributor selling teams ($t = 9.20$, $p < .000$) are more likely to be used. Finally, when more than one member of the buying center must be influenced in a single selling session, all types of selling teams are more likely to be used (within-firm selling teams, $t = 8.81$, $p < .000$; principal selling teams, $t = 8.70$, $p < .000$; distributor selling teams, $t = 7.15$, $p < .000$). Thus, results support *H2–5*.

TABLE 1
Results Table for Team Selling by Manufacturers' Representatives

Hyp. No.	Team Selling Is more Likely Used by Manufacturers' Representatives When:	W/ within-firm	Sig.	W/ principal	Sig.	W/ distributor	Sig.
H1	The information needs of the customer are great	$t = 16.06$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 18.34$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 9.95$, $p < .000$	Sig.
H2	The customer has not purchased the product previously.	$t = 6.10$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 5.35$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 6.41$, $p < .000$	Sig.
H3	The product is complex.	$t = 20.70$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 17.67$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 7.57$, $p < .000$	Sig.
H4	The account requires special treatment.	$t = 14.75$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 14.93$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 9.20$, $p < .000$	Sig.
H5	The number of people needing to be influenced in one session is greater.	$t = 8.81$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 8.70$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 7.15$, $p < .000$	Sig.
H6	The size of the sale to the reps org. is greater.	$t = 13.15$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 18.83$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 9.98$, $p < .000$	Sig.
H7	Introducing a product that is new to the product line.	$t = 3.98$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 11.46$, $p < .000$	Sig.	$t = 7.01$, $p < .000$	Sig.

Results also confirmed that all three kinds of selling teams are likely to be used in some selling situations. When the potential sale is very large, within-firm selling teams (t $= 13.15$, $p < .000$), principal selling teams (t $=$ 18.83, $p < .000$), and distributor selling teams (t $= 9.98$, $p < .000$) are more likely to be used. Selling teams are more likely to be used when the product is new to the selling firm (within-firm selling teams, t $= 3.98$, $p <$ .000; principal selling teams, t $= 11.46$, $p < .000$; distributor selling teams, t $= 7.01$, $p < .000$). Thus, *H6* and *7* were supported.

MANAGERIAL IMPLICATIONS

Although team selling is used by most manufacturers' representatives, there is a paucity of empirical research dealing with this subject, and little is known of situations in which manufacturers' representatives are likely to engage in team selling. Therefore, although this is an exploratory study, it can serve as a blueprint to manufacturers' representatives in understanding situations where other representatives use team selling with principals, with others from their own firm, or with distributors. This might be when information needs of the customer are great, when the customer has not purchased the product previously, when the product is complex, when the account requires special treatment, when the number of people needing to be influenced in one session is greater, when the size of the sale is greater, or when introducing a product new to the product line. Manufacturers' representatives not using team selling in these situations may be missing an opportunity to improve their sales success.

Alternatively, manufacturers' representatives who are using team selling in situations where other representatives are not may be incurring unnecessary costs. There might be situations where information needs of customers are small, when this is a routine buy for the customer, when products are very simple, where the account requires standard treatment, when only one person in the account must be influenced in one session, when the sale is small, or when it is a product that the representative has experience selling. Although these are not hard and fast rules, they do give manufacturers' representatives an overview of situations where other representatives are likely to use team selling and situations where they are less likely to use team selling.

In addition, the findings of this study also would be useful to manufacturers who use manufacturers' representatives by giving them insight into situations where other manufacturers are likely to accompany their representatives and situations where they are less likely to use team selling. Finally, distributors who are serviced by manufacturers' representatives can examine how likely representatives are to team up with other distributors in certain situations.

The results show that selling teams are more likely to be used by manufacturers' representatives when dealing with customers facing some kinds of buying situations. Selling teams are more likely to be used when the buyer faces a first-time buy as opposed to a routine buy, the

> Findings are useful to manufacturers who use manufacturers' representatives.

product is complex, the account requires special treatment, and a number of people in the account need to be influenced in one session. These buying situations are characterized by the need for information by the buyer. Thus, manufacturers' representatives should examine each situation faced by their buyers to determine the amount and kinds of information required by the buyers. When those information needs are great and diverse, the use of selling teams can enhance the effectiveness of the selling effort. The situations identified above are likely to be only a few indicators of such buying situations.

In addition, results show that the use of selling teams is more beneficial when facing certain types of selling situations. Selling teams are more likely to be used when the potential sale is large and important for the representative firm and when the product is new to the seller's product line. In these cases, the use of selling teams can enhance relationships with large customers and ensure the dissemination of appropriate information to customers to facilitate their purchase decision.

Another interesting managerial implication is that some manufacturers' representatives indicated that they did not use team selling with principals, within their own firm, or with distributors. These firms may be missing an opportunity to increase their sales. Although the present study did not examine the effectiveness of team selling, the fact that it is so widely used probably indicates that there is some benefit to team selling by manufacturers' representatives.

LIMITATIONS AND SUGGESTIONS FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

This study supports the use of selling teams in various buying and selling situations. The results, however, are subject to some limitations. One limitation of the study is that it only looked at team selling from the perspective of manufacturers' representatives and not from the perspective of principals, distributors, or customers. Future research may want to examine team selling from these perspectives. Future research should examine principals' perceptions of team selling. How do they perceive team selling? Do they view team selling as a way to monitor representatives' performance, as sales support, or as a form of training? Principals' perceptions of the value of team selling would also be interesting to explore in future research. Many of these same questions could also be explored from the distributors' perspective. Future research should also examine customers' perceptions of why team selling was used, how effective team selling was, and where they would like to see team selling used. It would also be interesting to examine customers' perceptions of the competency, expertise, and level of autonomy of manufacturers' representatives who used team selling with principals and with distributors.

There are also several methodological limitations of the study. First, single-item measures were used to assess the extent of selling team use in various buying and selling situations. Thus, the reliability and validity of the measures cannot be evaluated. Discussions with manufacturers' representatives, however, confirmed the face validity of the measures. Future research may want to confirm the use of selling teams in different situations using multi-item measures. A second limitation was the relatively low response rate on the mail portion of the study. A suggestion for further research might be to replicate the mail portion of the study, possibly offering incentives for participants. A third potential methodological limitation may have resulted from the wording of some of the language in the measures used in the study. Specifically, there could have been some confusion about "special treatment" or "complex products." The discussions in the pretest did not indicate that these were confusing to the subjects. However, future research may want to provide descriptions of special treatment and complex products. Fourth, the sample was limited to manufacturers' representatives. Thus, a limitation is that it cannot be generalized to manufacturer-owned salesforces. A suggestion for future research would be to replicate the study on other groups of salespeople such as manufacturers.

Because this was an exploratory study, there are numerous areas for future research that were not explored. First, it would be interesting to know how the teams were formed. Second, it would be interesting to know who was in control of the teams: the principal; the manufacturers' representative; or the distributor?

Although the current research examined situations in which team selling was used, several areas need further examination. It would be useful to know: how the composition of the team varies across different situations; how the size of the team varied across different situations; and whether the teams were formal or informal in nature across the various situations. Future research is needed to determine the relative effectiveness of selling teams versus individual sales representatives in various buying and selling situations; for example, when the people in the buying center come from diverse backgrounds or when the sales process is very complex.

Team selling between principals and manufacturers' representatives and between manufacturers' representatives and distributors within a channels context has several benefits beyond increasing sales. First, it may serve to bond the various channel members into partnerships [1]. Second, it may foster cooperation within the channel [18]. Third, team selling may foster better communication and trust between channel members [4]. Fourth, team selling within the channel keeps various channel members informed about the actions and perspectives of the other members. By keeping informed about the actions of other channel members and observing their results, team selling between channel intermediaries also may be a form of control [18]. Finally, by keeping the various channel members informed, team selling may also reduce conflict [26]. Despite benefits that might accrue to channel members from better partnering, there has been no empirical work examining the effect of team selling on these channel relationships. Thus, further research is needed.

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APPENDIX A

Questions Used to Test Hypotheses

Hypothesis 1
The anticipated information needs of the customer are great.
The anticipated information needs of the customer are small.
Hypothesis 2
This is a first time buy for the customer.
This is a routine buy for the customer.
Hypothesis 3
The product is very complex.
The product is very simple.
Hypothesis 4
The account requires special treatment.
The account requires standard treatment.
Hypothesis 5
A number of people in the account need to be influenced in one session.
Only one person in the account must be influenced in one session.
Hypothesis 6
The potential sale is very large for you.
The potential sale is very small for you.
Hypothesis 7
The product is new to your product line.
This is a product you have experience selling.